

**Understanding Political Controversy
PSCI 1104
Garland 162
T/TH 2:45pm-4:00pm**

Professor Trounstone

Fall 2026

Office: Commons 363A

E-mail: jessica.l.trounstone@vanderbilt.edu

Office Hours: Thursdays 10:30am-12pm

Course Description and Goals

This course is an introduction to applying the tools of scientific inquiry to the study of politics. The goal of this class is to teach you how to think like a political scientist. We will learn the basics of research design, hypothesis testing, and measurement and explore a number of different methodological approaches for answering political questions including experiments, descriptive and inferential statistics, and qualitative analysis. Each week we will dissect a contemporary political debate. We will analyze causal claims made in popular discourse and evaluate whether or not such claims are based on evidence political scientists find convincing. We will challenge conventional wisdom by thinking analytically. Students will be expected to demonstrate conceptual understanding of social science research and engage in rigorous scientific reasoning and critical thinking.

Requirements and Expectations

Students will be assessed according to their knowledge of the course materials and their ability to analyze, explain, and apply their knowledge to new and different contexts. Students who are regularly prepared for class and active in discussion also tend to earn higher grades on their quizzes and exams.

You are expected to attend class and do all of the reading. Class discussion will be based on the assumption that you have completed the reading for that day and are able to analyze the content.

Your grade will be based on four components.

Quizzes (5% each):	30%
Midterm:	30%
Final:	35%
Attendance	5%

At the end of the semester, your grade will be assigned based on the following scale: A (93-100), A- (90-92), B+ (87-89), B (83-86), B- (80-82), C+ (77-79), C (73-76), C- (70-72), D (60-69), and F (0-59).

Quizzes

There will be **six** quizzes that comprise 30% of the total grade. Quizzes will assess your knowledge of key readings, facts, and concepts covered in the preceding weeks. All quizzes will have a take home component and an in-class component. The take home component will be posted at 9am on the day prior to the quiz date and will be due before class begins on the quiz date.

Quiz dates are: **September 15th, September 24th, October 6th, October 29th, November 10th, and December 3rd**

Midterm

The midterm will be in class on **October 15th**. It is worth 30% of the grade.

Final

The final exam will be a cumulative, in-person exam on **December 17th** from 9-11am. It is worth 35% of the grade.

Attendance

As a way of measuring how well you are understanding class material, allowing you to express your opinions, and generating our own data, we will be using surveys throughout the semester. I will pose a question, and you will answer using your phone, laptop, or tablet.

Students are required to sign up for a Top Hat account and join the class using the join code 782449. Instructions are available here: <https://tinyurl.com/vandytophat04>

We will start using this technology in the second week of class, so you should set up your Top Hat account right away. To encourage your participation 5% of your final grade will be determined by your attendance. If you attend 75% of classes, you will receive 100% for your participation grade. If your participation falls below 75%, you will receive a proportion of credit based on your rate of participation (i.e. if you only attend 50% of classes this semester, you will receive half of the participation points for the semester).

If you are not well or have been exposed to an illness, please do not come to class. These absences will be excused, and you will receive attendance points as long as you email me to let me know.

Readings

There is one textbook for this class (available at the bookstore) and supplemental readings that are uploaded to Brightspace.

Required Text: Pollock, Philip and Barry Edwards. 2026. *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, 7th edition, CQ Press

Academic Honesty

Cheating will not be tolerated. You must write your own quizzes and exams. Plagiarism involves intentionally representing someone else's words or ideas as your own, including AI technology. If you cheat or let someone else represent your work as their own, you are in violation of the student honor code. As a result, you will fail this course and your failing grade will be identified on your student transcript as resulting from academic dishonesty. Suspected honor code violations will be reported to the Honor Council. Please consult the student handbook if you require further information:

https://www.vanderbilt.edu/student_handbook/the-honor-system/.

Course Outline

Week 1

Lecture 1 August 27: Introduction

- Fisman, Ray, Andrew Gelman, and Matthew C. Stephenson. "The Statistics that Come Out of

Nowhere.”

Week 2

Lecture 2 September 1: Research in political science: Theory driven research

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Introduction and Chapter 1
- Bueno de Mesquita, Ethan and Anthony Fowler. 2021. *Thinking Clearly with Data*, Chapter 3

Lecture 3 September 3: NO CLASS (Professor at American Political Science Association Meeting)

Week 3

Lecture 4 September 8: Measurement and Data Description

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 2-3
- Pollock & Edwards, Getting Started With R
 - Download R: <https://cloud.r-project.org/>
 - Download RStudio: <https://posit.co/download/rstudio-desktop/>

Lecture 5 September 10: What’s the Matter with Kansas?

- Messerli, Frank H. 2012. “Chocolate Consumption, Cognitive Function, and Nobel Laureates,” *New England Journal of Medicine*.” DOI: [10.1056/NEJMon1211064](https://doi.org/10.1056/NEJMon1211064)
- Ruffini, Patrick. 2023. “The Emerging Working-Class Republican Majority,” *Politico.com*. Accessed at: <https://www.politico.com/news/magazine/2023/11/04/new-republican-party-working-class-coalition-00122822>
- Frank, Thomas. “Lie down for America: How the Republican Party sows ruin on the Great Plains,” *Harpers Magazine*, April 2004, p 33-46
- Bartels, Larry. 2006. “What’s the Matter with What’s the Matter with Kansas?” *Quarterly Journal of Political Science*, 1: 201-226.

Week 4

Lecture 6 September 15: Hypotheses

- Quiz #1
- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 4-5

Lecture 7 September 17: Who Receives Public Assistance?

- Gilens, Martin, *Why Americans Hate Welfare: Race, Media, and the Politics of Antipoverty Policy*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, Chapters 5-6

Week 5

Lecture 8 September 22: Understanding and identifying causality I

- Kellstedt and Whitten, *Fundamentals of Political Science Research*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2009, Chapter 3

Lecture 9 September 24: Racial Profiling

- Quiz #2
- Bloomberg, Michael R. “‘Stop and Frisk’ is not Racial Profiling,” *The Washington Post*, August 18th 2013
- Bertrand, Marianne, and Sendhil Mullainathan. 2004. “Are Emily and Greg More Employable Than Lakisha and Jamal? A Field Experiment on Labor Market Discrimination.” *American Economic Review*, 94 (4): 991-1013.

Week 6

Lecture 10 September 29: Understanding and identifying causality II: Research Design

- Johnson, Janet Buttolph, H.T. Reynolds, and Jason Mycoff. 2016. *Political Science Research Methods*, 8th edition. Sage, Chapter 6

Lecture 11 October 1: Money Buys Votes

- <https://www.opensecrets.org/resources/dollarocracy/>

- Wright, John. 1996. *Interest Groups and Congress: Lobbying, Contributions, and Influence*. Needham Heights, MA: Allyn and Bacon. p115-116, 136-157
- Hertel-Fernandez, Alexander et al. 2018. "Legislative Staff and representation in Congress" *American Political Science Review* 113(1): 1-18

Week 7

Lecture 12 October 6: Experimental research and the logic of control

- Quiz #3
- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 6
- Gerber, Alan, Donald Green, and Christopher Larimer. 2008. "Social Pressure and Voter Turnout: Evidence from a Large-Scale Field Experiment." *American Political Science Review* 102(1): 33-48.

Lecture 13 October 8: Controlling for Confounding Factors without Experiments I

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 7

Week 8

Lecture 14 October 13: Controlling for Confounding Factors without Experiments II

- Leighley, Jan and Jonathan Nagler. 2014. *Who Votes Now?: Demographics, Issues, Inequality, and Turnout in the United States*, Chapter 2

Lecture 15 October 15: **Midterm Exam**

Week 9

Lecture 16 October 20: Social Science Experiments

Lecture 17 October 22: **Fall Break**

Week 10

Lecture 18 October 27: Survey Research I – Drawing a Sample

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 8 (p193-196)
- Moore, David and William Notz, *Statistics: Concepts and Controversies*, p 35-40, 57-71

Lecture 19 October 29: Survey Research II: Polling Errors

- Quiz #4
- Moore, David and William Notz, *Statistics: Concepts and Controversies*, p 41-48
- Cohn, Nate. 2016. "We Gave Four Good Pollsters the Same Raw Data" *The Upshot*
- Clinton, Joshua. 2024. "How Much does Weighting Matter?"
- Hillygus, Sunshine. 2011. "The Evolution of Election Polling in the United States," *Public Opinion Quarterly* 75(5): 962-981

Week 11

Lecture 20 November 3: The Rise of Independents

- Kahn, Huma, "Independent Voters on the Rise," ABC News Blog, January 9, 2012
- Brooks, David. "What Independents Want," *New York Times*, November 5th, 2009.
- Keith, Bruce et al. 1992. *The Myth of the Independent Voter*. Oxford: University of California Press. Chapters 1 & 10
- Fowler, Anthony et.al. 2023. "Moderates," *American Political Science Review*. 117 (2):643-660

Lecture 21 November 5: Understanding Probability and the Normal Distribution

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 8

Week 12

Lecture 22 November 10: Inferring the Truth*

- Quiz #5

Lecture 23 November 12: Statistical Significance and the Uses of Inference

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 9

Week 13

Lecture 24 November 17: Statistical Significance and the Uses of Inference Again

Lecture 25 November 19: Crime and Imprisonment

- Gladwell, Malcom, "The Tipping Point: Why is the city suddenly so much safer – could it be that crime really is an epidemic?" *The New Yorker*. June 3, 1996
- Levitt, Steven. 2004. "Understanding Why Crime Fell in the 1990s: Four Factors that Explain the Decline and Six that Do Not," *Journal of Economic Perspectives*. 18 (1): 163-190.
- Sampson, Robert and Alix Winter. 2018. "Poisoned Development: Assessing Childhood Lead Exposure as a Cause of Crime in a Birth Cohort followed through adolescence," *Criminology* 56(2)

Week 14

Lectures 26 & 27 November 24 & 26: Thanksgiving Break

Week 15

Lecture 28 December 1: Exploring Causal Relationships with Correlation and Regression

- Pollock, *The Essentials of Political Analysis*, Chapter 11

Lecture 29 December 3: Causal Relationships in Campaigns

- Quiz #6
- Kaufmann, Karen, John Petrocik, and Daron Shaw. 2008. *Unconventional Wisdom: Facts and Myths about American Voters*. New York: Oxford University Press. Chapter 8

Week 16

Lecture 30 December 8: Causal Inference in Small Numbers

- King, Keohane and Verba, *Designing Social Inquiry*, Princeton University Press, 1994. "Intentional Selection of Observations" (pp. 139-149)
- "Why Do Drug Dealers Still Live with Their Moms?" Chapter 3 in Levitt, Steven and Stephen Dubner. 2005. *Freakonomics: A Rogue Economist Explores the Hidden Side of Everything*. New York: Harper Collins

Lecture 31 December 10: Final Review

*****Final Exam, 9-11am, December 17th*****